So I slowly chipped away at the list to cut it down, excluding some people because their work did not fall within the time period of the book (roughly the 1920s to 2000) and some because there just wasn't enough verifiable information available. I also excluded people in order to balance the numbers between those who continue to be celebrated and those who, through no fault of their own, have largely been forgotten. And finally, in order to make the list as widely representative as possible, I preferentially included as many people as I could from traditionally marginalized communities.

The final and perhaps hardest task was trying to compress a person's whole life and work into a few hundred words. Every one of the people you will read about seem to have packed three lifetimes' worth of living into one. This made the process of researching and writing about them both time-consuming and difficult, for the more I learned, the more I wanted to say about each person. I found myself despairing over how I could possibly to do them justice within the limited space available. How could I encapsulate their rich, complex lives and legacies in so few words?

Inevitably, I have had to leave a lot out.

And so, at last, I arrived at a list of seventy-five individuals who shaped modern India. Some of them, such as MK Gandhi or Jawaharlal Nehru, continue to be idolized or seen as heroic figures. Others, such as Muthulakshmi Reddy or Jayaprakash Narayan, created a sensation when they were alive, but are less well-known today. And still others, like Gaura Devi are rarely ever mentioned. I have deliberately tried to steer clear of presenting people as heroes or villains, which is all too often the manner in which the makers of modern India are spoken of. Instead, I have tried to write as impartially as possible about people who, in a variety of ways and for better or for worse, played a part in shaping the history and progress of the modern Indian nation. I find them all endlessly fascinating. I hope you will too.

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